

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, July 8, 2020, via Zoom.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:32 p.m.

Mayor Lovett read the following statement: *This meeting is being conducted in accordance with the provisions of the Governor's Executive Order no. 2020-04 and the emergency meeting provisions of RSA 91-A to permit participation of board members by electronic means. Under the conditions of the current COVID-19 pandemic and the protocols established by the Centers for Disease Control (CDC), it is not reasonably practical for a quorum of this board's members to attend this meeting in person.*

Join by Telephone:

1-646-558-8656

Webinar ID: 824 5364 7887

Password: 136740

If there is a problem getting through to that number, please call 603-542-7002.

Members of the Council present were:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O'Hearne – Council Chambers – Councilors Stone & Sweetser

At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier – Sister's house, NC – Alone

At-Large Councilor Erica Sweetser – Council Chambers – Councilors Stone & O'Hearne

Assistant Mayor Allen Damren – Home – Alone

Mayor Charlene Lovett – Home – Alone

At-Large Councilor Debora Matteau – Home – Alone

At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski – Restaurant – Alone

Ward II Councilor James Contois – Home – Wife

Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone – Council Chambers – Councilors O'Hearne & Sweetser

Also present:

Edward Morris, City Manager

AGENDA CHANGES

None.

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor O'Hearne to accept the minutes of the May 30, 2020, City Council meeting, as amended.

Councilor Kier said on page 11, she would like to add a note indicating that she had discussed wanting to add the other firefighter position. That would indicate why she said no.

Mayor Lovett said on page 7, at the end of the cemetery discussion, she had asked for \$8,000 to be transferred from the Cemetery Capital Reserve fund.

Mayor Lovett said on page 12 that Mr. Brislin's department oversees ten parks. She thinks it should state seven parks. [It was confirmed by re-listening to the recording and verifying with the department, that Parks and Recreation oversees ten parks.]

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

A motion was made by Councilor Stone and seconded by Councilor Contois to accept the minutes of the June 10, 2020, City Council meeting, as amended.

Mayor Lovett said on page 3, last paragraph, where she talked about unemployment benefits, it should read, "Mayor Lovett talked about pandemic unemployment assistance for people in the community and that these new benefits are being launched by the Department of Employment Security on June 11."

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor Stone to accept the minutes of the June 17, 2020, City Council meeting.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

A motion was made by Councilor O’Hearne and seconded by Councilor Stone to accept the minutes of the June 24, 2020, City Council meeting, as amended.

Mayor Lovett said on page 6, under Budget Hearing & Vote, that “Mr. Morris said the number used for this budget proposal was from the previous year...” should be more identifiable. Mr. Morris said the number used was the tax rate from the previous year.

Councilor Kier said on page 17, third line from the top, “he Js” should be “his.” On page 16, 4th paragraph when Councilor Stone questioned why she failed to notify the Council of her sister-in-law’s hiring, there’s no written response. She said she and Councilor Matteau replied to that and she would like it noted.

Roll call vote:
O’Hearne - yes
Kier - yes
Sweetser - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

MAYOR’S NOTES

Mayor’s Challenge

Mayor Lovett said Lebanon, Concord, Manchester, Nashua and Somersworth have signed on to this. If the Council is okay with this, she’ll sign on that Claremont supports policies at the Federal level to reduce energy costs for small businesses and low income families; job creation and public safety through innovation and investment in infrastructure; advance zero emissions technology; and expand clean energy.

Councilors agreed that she should move forward with this and Mayor Lovett will keep everyone posted.

CITY MANAGER'S REPORT

- **Drought** – Prior to the rain this week, the City and State were in a drought watch. With the recent rain, we are doing okay, but are still watching the reservoir. He urged citizens to conserve water.
- **Hydrant Testing-** Because of the drought watch, the City has decided to postpone hydrant testing until later in the year. Our ISO rating is not scheduled until 2021, and we have time between now and then to make sure our fire hydrants are tested.
- **Hazard Dam Inspections** - All of our 4 high hazard dams have been under a letter of deficiency for quite a while, since around 2008. Two of the dams now have a letter of compliance. The other 2 dams, Whitewater and Dole, should now be compliant as the deficiencies were repaired last summer, but we have not yet received the official compliance letters.
- **Regional Dispatch** – Meeting with the Town of Newport in an effort to plan the possibility of a regional communications center. Currently looking at having a stand-alone entity that is independently board managed. The project would greatly reduce the overall cost of each organization purchasing their own equipment, and preliminary numbers show a small decrease in operational costs for each entity. The hope is to find more efficiencies as we move forward, and to get more cities/towns to participate, which will create more cost savings per entity. \$1 million has been placed in the bond in case we have to go with this on our own and have to replace radios, etc.
- **Arrowhead** – Work has begun at Arrowhead on the Energy Efficiency Upgrades that were funded through unanticipated revenue from the State of New Hampshire. The first phase of this project is complete and that was to replace the windows and doors. The next two phases include replacing the roof and the replacement of the furnace, and the addition of an A/C unit. The roofing project is set to begin the first week of July 2020.
- **Maintenance of City Properties** - The City is currently in the middle of transitioning to a Facilities Division that will be charged with the care and maintenance of all City-owned facilities. Prior to this change, we had a City Complex maintenance staff, Community Center and Parks staff, and other City buildings, and property maintenance was taken care of by each department.
- **CCTV Status** – If Assistant Mayor Damren is reappointed to the CCTV Board of Directors, as requested at the last Council meeting, there will be one vacant seat of the four that the City appoints. The School Board currently has two vacant seats, and

he has reached out to Superintendent Tempesta to let him know of these needed appointments. That leaves one vacant seat to be appointed by the members of the board.

COVID-19 Update

From Mr. Morris:

- City continues to slowly open services. He believes next week the Library will be fully open to the public. Claremont Savings Bank Community Center (CSBCC) is still somewhat restricted, per guidelines. All other City offices are open. Mask wearing is strongly encouraged. It is a mandate that all employees wear masks, if they are in a space that can be accessed by the public.
- The City has seen a small uptick of cases. There are up to 5 cases in Claremont.
- Bid for the 139 Main Street Project are due July 10.
- NH Main Street Relief – Claremont received \$2.5 million through 46 of our local businesses

Regarding facilities, Mr. Morris said that he will be putting people where they can coordinate work. Staff is not expected to change. Right now, Tim Hernon reports to Parks and Recreation Director Mark Brislin and Bill Willette and others report to Finance Director Mary Walter. Mr. Morris will move them all to report under Mr. Brislin.

Regarding COVID-19 testing, Councilor Stone asked for the next meeting to have the numbers per day. Fire Chief Bryan Burr said the numbers fluctuate, 30-50. Testing has dropped off since the reopening of the community. Mr. Morris said he can email out the numbers.

Councilor Sweetser asked if there will be a joint meeting of the Council and School Board anytime soon. Mayor Lovett will reach out to the chair of the board to try to startup the quarterly meetings.

Councilor Contois said regarding talk of loosening up, there are 386 dead people in NH. He wants to stress that fact because we are in a pandemic.

Because of recent citizen complaints about School Street, Councilor Koloski would like an update. Mr. Morris will work on that.

Councilor Sweetser said she has received a citizen complaint about an unsecured air conditioner on Pleasant Street. She said there are a lot of unsupported AC units hanging out over the sidewalk. Mr. Morris can check into that.

Councilor O'Hearne asked if the decision to make a Facilities Division would come to the Council for approval. Mr. Morris said if it works out and it's decided to make it official, it would.

Councilor Koloski asked about the NICE (Neighborhood Improvements through Code Enforcement) Committee. He has received a complaint about a Broad Street property not being mowed. Mr. Morris said the NICE Committee is being reinstated. Regarding lawn mowing, the City can ask them to do it, but it's not in the ordinance, so we can't mandate it.

APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES

Airport Advisory Board

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor Matteau to re-appoint Stephen Keen to seat 4 of the Airport Advisory Board.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

A motion was made by Councilor Stone and seconded by Assistant Mayor Damren to re-appoint David Eno to seat 2 of the Airport Advisory Board.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Claremont Community Television, Inc. Board of Directors

On the agenda, under APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES, Allen Damren's name was listed for CCTV Board of Directors.

A motion was made by Councilor Kier and seconded by Councilor Matteau to appoint Allen Damren to seat 1, City Council Representative, of the Claremont Community Television, Inc. Board of Directors.

Councilor Stone said that he had wanted to nominate Councilor O'Hearne for the seat.

Councilor Koloski said that typically, Councilors are asked if they have any interest in sitting on the board, and then nominations are made.

Mayor Lovett said that Assistant Mayor Damren had registered his interest in the past. This is the first she had heard of Councilor O'Hearne's interest in the seat.

Both, Assistant Mayor Damren and Councilor O'Hearne expressed their desire to sit on the board.

After discussion, Councilor Matteau withdrew her second, and without a second, Councilor Kier withdrew her motion.

Councilor Kier nominated and Councilor Contois seconded Allen Damren for seat 1, City Council Representative, of the Claremont Community Television, Inc. Board of Directors.

Councilor Stone nominated and Councilor Koloski seconded Andrew O'Hearne for seat 1, City Council Representative, of the Claremont Community Television, Inc. Board of Directors.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne – O'Hearne

Kier - Damren

Sweetser - O'Hearne

Damren - Damren

Matteau - O'Hearne

Koloski - O'Hearne

Contois - Damren

Stone - O'Hearne

Lovett - Damren

Councilor O'Hearne appointed (O'Hearne-5, Damren-4).

A motion was made by Councilor Matteau and seconded by Councilor O'Hearne to appoint Allan Berggren to seat 4 of the Claremont Community Television, Inc. Board of Directors.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

Frances J. Tolles Home Trustees

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor Matteau to re-appoint Jacquelyn Hall to seat 4 of the Frances J. Tolles Home Trustees.

Roll call vote:
O'Hearne - yes
Kier - yes
Sweetser - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

A motion was made by Councilor Kier and seconded by Assistant Mayor Damren to re-appoint Deborah Snelling to seat 7 of the Frances J. Tolles Home Trustees.

Roll call vote:
O'Hearne - yes
Kier - yes
Sweetser - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

CITIZEN'S FORUM

Joe Osgood, Ward 1, said he was concerned because at the last meeting, someone sent a statement to the Mayor to be read. He was not in favor of asking a Councilor to read a prepared statement into the record. However, he's okay with a single sentence being read. He agreed with written testimony with a request that it be added to the minutes, word-for-word. Mr. Osgood was concerned about cars that are up on jacks/blocks that are unattended for days; it's

dangerous. He said between 22 and 42 Chestnut Street is City-owned land and there are two vehicles on there that are jacked up and wheels are off.

Walt Stapleton, Ward 3, said he sent an email to the Council and City Manager regarding the holiday display and to use it at will. He said the Vermonter Amtrak train is funded by the state of Vermont and they will determine when it resumes operation. He heard it might be some time in August, depending on the COVID situation.

Rebecca MacKenzie, Ward 2, thanked Mayor Lovett for her leadership in the Mayor's Challenge. She is a member of the Energy Advisory Committee, she's excited about the different projects that could be funded regarding our need for energy projects. She said she heard Mr. Morris talk about the Whitewater Reservoir and that it is not operational. Perhaps we could use some funds to make it operational. She said that the Energy Advisory Committee is in need of members. She agreed with the experts that we should be wearing masks and social distancing.

OLD BUSINESS

Legislative Update

Mayor Lovett said it is important to start thinking about LSRs (Legislative Service Requests) that the Council would want the Delegation to submit in, she believes, September. She will put together a list of discussions and will put it on for discussion at the next meeting.

Holiday Display Policy Discussion

Mayor Lovett said that included in the packet was the Policy Committee's recommendation. Council needs to go through the process to have Legal counsel review and format it into a policy.

Councilor Stone would like to reinstate the Policy Committee with the next meeting being August 23 and to make this one of its priorities. The Committee can meet in person and on Zoom.

Mayor Lovett would like to finalize this before November. There was consensus to have this go to the Policy Committee to work with Legal counsel to format this into a policy. She said to meet the timeframes for this holiday season, the ordinance would have to go before the Council for first reading no later than the second meeting in September.

Pleasant Street Presentation

Nancy Merrill, Planning and Development Director, said that the Rethink Pleasant Street Revitalization Project presentation had been given to the public earlier tonight. Brian Colburn, Roadway Design, McFarland Johnson, and Johnathan Law, Landscape Architect, IBI Placemaking, showed the PowerPoint presentation to the Council.

- Agenda
- Project Overview
 - Franklin Street, Glidden Street, Broad Street, Opera House Square, Sullivan Street
- Public Input To-Date
 - Six meetings/public listening sessions/workshops from January 10, 2019, through July 8, 2020.
- Project Goal: Rethink Pleasant Street from Moving Cars to Attracting People
 - Creating a destination
 - Pedestrian friendly – wider sidewalks
 - Facilitate economic development
 - Increase downtown parking options
 - Reducing truck traffic
- Alternative #1
 - Maintain current configuration
 - 42 on-street parking spots (5 fewer spaces)
 - Sidewalk width = 9'-6" (same as existing)
- Alternative #2
 - One-way southbound
 - Parking on one side
 - 38 on-street parking spots (9 fewer spaces)
 - Sidewalk width = 16'-6" (7' wider than existing)
- Alternative #3
 - One-way southbound
 - Parallel parking
 - 23 on-street parking spots (24 fewer spaces)
 - Sidewalk width = 21' (11'-6" wider than existing)
- Preferred Alternative
 - Alternative #2
 - Balance of vehicle/people space
 - Maintained most on-street parking
 - Opportunities for multiple uses
- Implementation
 - Additional off-street parking
 - Revised traffic flow
 - Glidden & Broad improvements
 - Truck route
 - Streetscape
- Additional Off-Street Parking
- Additional Parking
 - Reconfiguration/merging of existing lots
 - Additional on-street parking
 - Property owner coordination
 - 112 additional parking spaces
 - Roughly 25% increase
 - Improve lighting

- Improve signage
- Revised Traffic Flow
- Existing Traffic Pattern
- New Traffic Pattern
 - Pleasant Street one-way
 - Glidden Street one-way
 - Performed traffic counts in early March 2020 pre-pandemic closure
 - Current Stop sign at Glidden will be excessive
 - Propose traffic signal at Glidden
 - Impacts parallel parking, offset by off-street parking
- Truck Route
 - Northbound
 - Signage to take right onto Pleasant Street, right onto South Street, and then left onto Broad Street
 - Deliveries can be made on Pleasant Street and in the downtown
 - Southbound is a little longer
 - North Street turn left onto Main Street, right onto Union Street, right onto Mulberry, then back to Pleasant
 - Modify Union Street, move Stop back
 - Union/Mulberry Street intersection, make island slightly larger

Johnathan Law continued with the presentation.

- Streetscape
- Concept 2
 - Plant more trees, increase property value, slow traffic, reduce storm water runoff, provide natural shade
 - New sidewalks
 - Furniture zone brick & granite
 - New benches, bike racks, plantings
- Images
 - Entrance to Pleasant Street not inviting
 - Wider sidewalks reduce crossing width
 - Place for public art
 - More places for people to gather
 - Dining areas, increase vibrancy
 - Surface planting improve storm water runoff
 - Bike lane
 - Parking stations
 - LED lighting, dark sky compliant
 - Brick furniture zone
 - Potential bike sharing
 - Plantings would be drought & salt tolerant, no planned irrigation
 - Plantings create buffer between pedestrians & vehicles
 - Inclusive, want to make everyone feel welcome

Mr. Colburn continued.

- Preliminary Cost Estimates

- Design \$150,000
- Construction Roadway \$3,100,000
- Construction Water \$360,000
- Construction Sewer \$290,000
- Streetscape \$650,000
- Total \$4.55 million

Assistant Mayor Damren said that all Councilors had received a letter from Tom Rock, Chair of the Claremont Development Authority (CDA), stating that the CDA is in favor of this project. Assistant Mayor Damren asked that the letter be included in the minutes. He referenced a letter sent to him from Susan Sadonsky asking the architect/developer rethink a certain section of the truck route. That letter has been sent on to Ms. Merrill.

Mr. Colburn said if the bond is approved, they are looking to start construction next year. It is expected to take a full construction season to complete the work.

Councilors were asked to forward any questions to the City Manager. Councilors agreed that questions and answers would be sent to all Councilors. The next Council meeting will focus on the financing and maintenance of the project area.

Councilor Sweetser said she has asked Mr. Morris for the history of revitalizing downtown. She asked what was spent on this plan and he said it was about \$200,000 over the last couple of years. There has been public input and these are the things the public wants. She wanted everyone to know that each time an idea comes along, but is not followed up on, it costs the City money.

Ordinance 575 Water Rates – First Reading

The purpose of this proposed change is to amend the City's 2021 water rates to reflect that the City now charges on a quarterly basis for this particular year and to make some minor adjustments to the 2021 rate schedule (with the majority of the 2021 rates remaining the same overall level of charge as the 2020 rates). The Covid-19 pandemic and resulting Emergency Orders by the State of New Hampshire have created economic hardship for both residents and businesses within the City. In particular, small business is expected to suffer the greatest financial losses associated with the shutdown and such impact will be felt well into 2021. In recognition of the adversity that businesses and residents must cope with in terms of a struggling economy, the City seeks to institute some level of relief in the form of avoiding an increase of the City's water rates for 2021.

It is the hope of the City that this avoidance of a water rate increase in 2021 will help, to some degree, with alleviating the financial stresses of the pandemic to allow residents as well as businesses to move forward and prosper in 2021. This change is requested by the City Manager.

Mayor Lovett said that Assistant Mayor Damren started to read the ordinance at the last meeting, however, it was written for semi-annual billing and the City now has quarterly billing, so he stopped and the ordinance was sent back for correction.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Contois to suspend Council Rules in order to not have to read the ordinance.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - no

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - no

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 7-2.

Mayor Lovett reminded everyone that this is to allow the water rates to stay the same for FY 2021 as they were for FY 2020.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Ms. Matteau to adopt Ordinance 575 Water Rates.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

NEW BUSINESS

CDBG Public Facility, Emergency and/or CDBG-CV Grant Application

Planning and Development Director Nancy Merrill said the homeless shelter is down to six beds because of code deficiencies and the Council had asked if CDBG (Community Development Block Grant) could help them out.

Keith Thibault, Southwestern Community Services, said the family shelter is at 45 Central Street. Without fire suppression, they are limited in the number of people they could house there. In addition to fire suppression, they would like to upgrade windows, flooring, cabinetry, etc. They received a grant last year for the Keene shelter and they appreciate the ability to apply for a block

grant to be able to house more residents. With the upgrades, they will be able to house 16 individuals, single women and families with children.

NOTE: Informational packets were available.

Mayor Lovett read from the script. Community Development Block Grant funds are available to municipalities through the NH Community Development Finance Authority. Up to \$500,000 annually is available on a competitive basis for public facility projects, up to \$500,000 for housing projects, up to \$500,000 for economic development projects and up to \$500,000 annually is available for emergency activities. Up to \$25,000 is available per planning study. All projects must primarily benefit low- and moderate-income persons.

A proposed application to the Community Development Finance Authority for up to \$500,000 in Community Development Block Grant Public Facility, Emergency and/or CDBG-CV funds. The City of Claremont may be requesting the project be considered as an emergency grant under the emergency and COVID response criteria. The CDBG funds will be used for improvements to the Southwest Community Service's Emergency Shelter, 45 Central Street, in Claremont. The facility is operating at only 50% capacity due to a portion of the building being unusable. Improvements to the facility includes, but is not limited to, repairs and upgrades of HVAC, sprinkler and electrical systems. The majority of the clients at the Shelter are of low and moderate income.

This project conforms with Claremont's Housing and Community Development Plan's Goal of: Encourage other services that will benefit low- and moderate-income persons. (Short-term and Long-term goal)

Mayor Lovett opened the public hearing and asked if anyone wished to make any comments. No one did. She closed the public hearing.

- 1) Review and Adopt or Re-adopt City's Residential Anti-Displacement and Relocation Assistance Plan – Public Hearing

Mayor Lovett read from the script: This Plan states in general, that if the City were to undertake a CDBG project which involved displacement and resulting relocation, they would follow the Uniform Relocation Act requirements. The Residential Antidisplacement and Relocation Assistance Plan outlines the measures they would take to find comparable, housing for persons (or businesses) displaced and/or relocation.

This project may require temporary relocation. If required, residents would be temporarily relocated to another SCS property in Claremont. SCS will pay relocations costs.

Mayor Lovett opened the public hearing and asked if anyone wished to make any comments. No one did. She closed the public hearing.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Ms. Kier to adopt the City's Residential Anti-Displacement and Relocation Assistance Plan.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor Contois to approve the submittal of the application and votes to authorize the City Manager to sign and submit the CDBG application, and upon approval of the CDBG application, authorize the City Manager to execute any documents which may be necessary to effectuate the CDBG contract, and any amendments thereto.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Airport Easement Project

Fire Chief Bryan Burr said the Airport Easement Project is outside of the Airport property. It directly affects the Airport Runway Project which is scheduled to start in 2021/2022. Through the Master Plan update, issues with aircraft safety, approach and landing, came to light. He introduced Amy Gray, Engineering Project Manager, Stantec, and Janice Bland, Senior Aviation Planner, Stantec, who showed a PowerPoint presentation.

Ms. Bland said the purpose of tonight's discussion was the easement acquisition project. An aviation easement grants the right to: remove obstructions to protected surfaces; restrict new structures (use and height). This protects the air space; restricts new structures (trees, buildings), and in this case, the obstructions are trees. She covered the Easement Acquisition Process. These easements are required for safety.

Ms. Gray, listed the Airport Projects including: Environmental Assessment, Airport Master Plan Update, New Terminal Building Construction, Terminal Apron Rehabilitation, Easement Acquisition (FAA Requirement, safety deficiency), obstruction removal, and Runway 11-29 rehabilitation. The trees have to be removed to avoid shortening the runway, and shutting down the airport. This is a supplemental funding project. Bids will go out in the Spring of 2021.

Ms. Bland said there are eight easements with seven owners. The easements are just for tree removal. The runway length would not change.

Resolution 2021-6 Condemning Police Brutality and Supporting Racial Justice – Public Hearing

WHEREAS, the City of Claremont strives to be a City where all people can feel protected, included, secure and safe; and

WHEREAS, the Claremont Police Department has denounced the actions taken by four members of the Minneapolis Police Department during the murder of George Floyd on May 25, 2020; and

WHEREAS, that horrific incident prompted communities all over the globe to acknowledge the inequalities of minority life in the United States; and

WHEREAS, the City Council recognizes the issues of systemic racism across the country and in our daily lives;

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED that the City Council will work with the Police Department alongside community leaders and advocates to understand the steps the Police Department has taken and can take to provide effective public safety, while ensuring accountability not only to the City Council and the City Manager's Office, but to the public as a whole and the City of Claremont.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the City Council and City Government will engage with willing community members, centering the voices of all stakeholders who have been historically marginalized or under-served by our present system. Together, we will identify what safety looks like for everyone; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the City Council will also endorse the City Government to reach out to the community and community leaders to develop educational opportunities within our community focusing on the diversity of the community and the understanding of other people and cultures. We demand investment in our community and resources to make sure that all people not only survive, but thrive; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the City will be invested in public health and community safety beyond policing strategies including evidence-based violence prevention programs, invest in community based educational systems, and support domestic violence advocacy; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that these efforts heed the words of Angela Davis, “In a racist society, it is not enough to be non-racist. We must be anti-racist.”

Councilor Kier said she wanted to put it out that this is what the Council believes. When asked, she said she worked with a City employee to write up the resolution.

Councilors had questions about whether or not the Police Commission had been involved in this. Police Chief Mark Chase said the Claremont Police Department is accredited by CALEA (Commission on Accreditation for Law Enforcement Agencies). In regard to the Police Commission, he said he is a strong advocate of civilian oversight for the Police Department. He would like to see the Police Commission included in this resolution. He said the Department has had use of force complaints and each complaint is thoroughly investigated.

There was a discussion about racial justice and social justice and Councilor Kier said they are intertwined.

After discussion, Councilors agreed some changes should be made. Mr. Morris said he will work with Councilor Kier on this.

Mayor Lovett said any suggested changes from Councilors should be submitted to Councilor Kier and Mr. Morris. This will go under Old Business at the next meeting.

Board of Assessors Membership Discussion

Mr. Morris said as part of the Board of Assessors (BOA) creation, members are not allowed to serve on any other board. This is a request to see if the Council would be willing to relook at this to see if the rule should specify which boards/commissions would be in conflict.

Councilor Koloski said when this was put into place, his intention was that no Councilor could sit on the BOA. He is okay with the limitation being just for Councilors. He has no problem changing it. Councilor Matteau agreed with Councilor Koloski.

Assistant Mayor Damren recommended that Mr. Morris and Interim Assessor Stephan Hamilton work on this.

Mr. Stephan Hamilton said he believes that he and Mr. Morris can look at the other boards and commissions to see what conflicts there are and bring a proposal back to the Council.

Councilor Kier concurred with Assistant Mayor Damren.

Councilor Koloski said he is not asking for this to go back to the Policy Committee.

Council agreed that Mr. Hamilton and Mr. Morris would work on this and bring a proposal back to the Council at the first meeting in August.

Abatement Update

Mr. Hamilton gave a recap of the BOA actions: 82 abatements (19 administrative abatements, 63 true abatement requests). The Assessing office has worked with them. He will come to the Council with a full list of abatements with dispositions. They approved two cases at the BTLA (Board of Tax & Land Appeals). Resolution of 1 of 2 cases at Superior Court, 1 case withdrawn. He gave kudos to the BOA and the Staff for their work.

Mayor Lovett said there is a requirement for the BOA to submit an annual report to the Council.

COMMITTEE REPORTS

Regarding the Finance Committee, Assistant Mayor Damren said that in the CIP (Capital Improvements Plan) Report, there was a recommendation to seriously consider addressing a capital reserve for the CIP items. The intent is to bring resolution to the Council at the next meeting to establish capital reserve fund with \$100,000 to come from unassigned fund balance.

Councilor Stone said the Policy Committee's next meeting will be August 23.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Mayor Lovett's notes:

- Review why overgrown grass is exempted from property management code.
- Helpful to have a Council Rule regarding nominating Councilors to boards/committees as well as reading letters into the record.

Councilor Sweetser would like to try to have a joint meeting with the School Board.

Councilor Koloski asked who will go through the process to write a Council Rule change. Mayor Lovett will do it.

Councilor Koloski requested the Council take a tour of the downtown in conjunction with the request for bonding/funding.

Councilor Koloski said there is some Amtrak signage with graffiti, and he asked if Amtrak should be contacted. Mayor Lovett said Public Works may have some extra signs. The City can order replacement signs free of charge. She can work with the City Manager, if the signs can't be cleaned and there are no extra signs, to order more from Amtrak.

Councilor Sweetser said she has been researching how to remove graffiti and she can share that information.

Councilor Koloski would like an update placed in the Council packet from the Conservation Commission regarding the trees with bands that have been protected from the emerald ash borer.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

At 10:06 p.m., a motion was made by Councilor Matteau and seconded by Councilor O'Hearne to adjourn.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council

Claremont Development Authority

14 North Street • Claremont • New Hampshire • 03743

July 8, 2020

Claremont City Council 58
Opera House Square
Claremont, NH 03743

Dear Ladies and Gentlemen of Claremont City Council,

The Claremont Development Authority unanimously supports the proposed Pleasant Street infrastructure upgrade project that will transform Claremont's historic downtown. Claremont's downtown, as one of its greatest assets, is vastly underutilized and its revitalization has long been a top priority by Claremont residents and business owners during years of vision sessions and city-wide surveys.

Committing to a pedestrian-friendly environment featuring wider sidewalks for enhanced retail and dining activity as well as outdoor spaces for entertainment and the arts will make the City Center a magnet that attracts people to our community. We believe this project will serve as a catalyst for additional economic development in our historic downtown district.

This commitment will send a strong message to private investors. Similar investments in the past paved the way for significant development on Water Street and the Brown and Farwell Blocks that brought new businesses to the Tax Increment Financing (TIF) district and City Center. Real estate values in the TIF district have grown from \$11 million prior to these projects to over \$26 million today. This is what commitment to revitalization can do.

Furthermore, revitalization of the City Center is a primary goal of the recently completed Master Plan. The city has already determined that significant investment is necessary to upgrade 100- year-old water and sewer infrastructure, and timing coincides with expiring municipal bond payments. What better time for the Pleasant Street Revitalization project than when interest rates are at all-time lows and contractors are eager for projects? There is no better time to make this vision a reality.

A model of what Claremont's downtown revitalization could be exists just up the road in White River Junction. Their commitment to revitalization has met with great success. Good things happen when a thoughtful plan is championed by community leaders willing to act. Downtown development that facilitates residential and commercial development with cultural and artistic activities is a proven formula for economic growth. This project is Claremont's opportunity make it happen right here, right now. This is precisely what our community needs to keep moving forward.

On behalf of the CDA, thank you very much for your consideration.

Tom Rock
Chair, Claremont Development Authority